

ABSOLUTE RELATIVE SYSTEMS

VOYAGEWRIGHT

Language Design Foundation

Clear first. Human always. Wonder earned.

Voice, tone, terminology, microcopy, error language,
and narrative speaker ownership for the Voyagewright platform.

Foundation v1.0 | July 2026

Document Purpose

This document defines how Voyagewright speaks. It governs the language of the public brand, the core platform, Player, Captain, Studio, errors, recovery states, and the boundary between platform copy and Chronicle-authored narrative.

It is intended to prevent the product from slowly mutating into twelve inconsistent dialects of nautical software, each written by a different screen at two in the morning.

Scope

This foundation defines voice and tone principles, canonical terminology, sentence-level standards, speaker ownership, emotional pacing, accessibility expectations, and examples for common interface states.

How to use this document

- Treat the voice principles as product requirements, not optional polish.
- Use the canonical glossary in UI labels, documentation, database-facing display names, and marketing copy.
- Keep platform language separate from Chronicle narration and character dialogue.
- Audit every new screen against the copy review checklist before release.
- Allow Chronicles to have their own voices while preserving platform clarity around them.

Contents

1. The voice thesis
 2. Voice and tone
 3. Six governing principles
 4. The six voice layers
 5. Error and recovery language
 6. Canonical vocabulary
 7. Microcopy transformations
 8. Sentence-level standards
 9. Language across the emotional arc
 10. Speaker ownership
 11. Nautical intensity
 12. Accessibility and localization
 13. Copy governance
 14. Definitive voice statement
- Appendix A. Sample copy library
- Appendix B. Copy review checklist

1. The Voice Thesis

Voyagewright speaks with measured wonder.

Voyagewright should sound like a trusted guide standing beside an unfinished map: clear enough that the user always knows what to do, poetic enough that the interface feels like part of the experience, warm enough to feel human, and restrained enough never to become corny.

A lantern, not a loudspeaker. A compass, not a monologue.

The voice is:

- Warm, but not sentimental by default.
- Precise, but not clinical.
- Observant, but not over-explanatory.
- Quietly imaginative, but never vague when action is required.
- Nautical in texture, not trapped in pirate costume.
- Confident, but never grandiose.
- Human, without pretending the system is a character unless a Chronicle explicitly provides one.

The central promise

Voyagewright helps creators build stories worth entering, helps Captains guide those stories, and helps players understand what is happening without draining the experience of mystery.

Internal shorthand

Clear first. Human always. Wonder earned.

2. Voice and Tone

The voice remains stable. The tone responds to the moment.

The voice is the underlying personality of the product. Tone is the temporary emotional posture used for a specific situation.

Context	Tone	Primary objective
Public landing page	Inviting and aspirational	Explain the product and create curiosity
Player experience	Mysterious and reassuring	Frame the Chronicle without overpowering it
Captain's Console	Focused and operational	Support fast, reliable live control
Voyagewright Studio	Clear and encouraging	Help creators build valid,

Context	Tone	Primary objective
		publishable Chronicles
Errors and recovery	Calm and direct	Explain impact, safety, and next action
Finale or reflection	Minimal and spacious	Let the Chronicle earn the emotion

Critical distinction

A confirmation dialog for deleting a Chronicle should not recite poetry about the cruel tide of impermanence. Tone serves the user's need before it serves atmosphere.

3. Six Governing Principles

These rules apply across the entire product.

3.1 Clear before clever

The user must never have to decode the interface itself. Atmosphere may accompany meaning, but it may not replace meaning.

GOOD	Awaiting the Captain. Your progress is saved. The next chapter will appear when it is released.
AVOID	The tide has not yet turned. Perhaps the keeper of the voyage still ponders what lies beyond.

3.2 Suggest wonder instead of announcing it

Voyagewright should rarely call something epic, magical, incredible, immersive, or unforgettable. The experience should earn those reactions.

GOOD	A new mark has appeared on the chart.
AVOID	An incredible magical discovery has been revealed!

3.3 Nautical texture, not pirate cosplay

Use nautical vocabulary when it improves identity and comprehension. Avoid fake pirate dialect in the platform voice.

GOOD	Return to your Chronicle Library.
------	-----------------------------------

AVOID

Sail back to yer trove of tales, matey!

3.4 Emotion is observed, not commanded

Present evidence and trust the player. Do not prescribe the correct emotional response.

GOOD

The second handwriting ends here. The remaining pages are his alone.

AVOID

This heartbreaking discovery fills you with sadness.

3.5 The player is capable and must never be shamed

Hints, wrong answers, recovery, and verification failures should preserve dignity and support progress.

GOOD

That answer does not fit the markings yet. Review the eastern symbol and try again.

AVOID

Incorrect. Try harder.

3.6 Humor creates breathing room

Humor should be dry, restrained, and situational. It belongs in harmless moments, not in security, privacy, billing, or data-loss states.

GOOD

No Chronicles found. Even legends have to be written first.

AVOID

Your database has sailed into the abyss, taking all mortal hope with it.

4. The Six Voice Layers

Voyagewright is a platform with multiple speakers, not one omnipresent narrator.

4.1 The Voyagewright brand voice

The most aspirational form of the voice. It may be poetic, but it must still explain what the product does.

Where it appears: Product website, Marketing pages, Trailer copy, Onboarding, Product descriptions, Public empty states.

- Create stories worth entering.
- Build a Chronicle. Gather your crew. Turn an ordinary game night into a voyage they will remember.
- Your games already provide the world. Voyagewright gives that world a story made for your crew.

4.2 The platform voice

Neutral, concise, lightly atmospheric, and never pretending to be a story character.

Where it appears: Navigation, Authentication, Invitations, Loading states, Settings, System notifications.

- Invitation accepted.
- Your voyage is ready.
- Progress saved.
- The next chapter has not been released.
- No active voyages.

4.3 The Chronicle narrator

This voice belongs to the Chronicle. It may be a Captain, scientist, ghost, archivist, dispatcher, unreliable narrator, or no narrator at all.

Where it appears: Narration, Journal entries, Letters, Character dialogue, Authored documents, Chronicle-specific prompts.

- Every Chronicle owns its own narrator and character voices.
- Voyagewright does not force nautical narration into non-nautical stories.
- Platform errors never masquerade as Chronicle prose.

4.4 The Player experience voice

A bridge between platform clarity and Chronicle atmosphere. Functional truth comes first; atmospheric meaning follows.

Where it appears: Chapter releases, Artifact reveals, Progress framing, Waypoint updates, Collection states.

- Chapter III released. A new entry has opened in the journal.
- Artifact recovered. The sea-glass lens has been added to your collection.
- A new Echo was found. Some places keep more than treasure.

4.5 The Captain interface voice

Operational, fast, and unambiguous. The Captain may be navigating, speaking, coordinating, and avoiding cannon fire at the same time.

Where it appears: Session controls, Approvals, Hints, Player status, Chapter releases, Live recovery.

- Release Chapter III

- Awaiting player confirmation
- Approve discovery
- Send Hint 2
- Pause voyage
- The player is offline. This action will be delivered when they reconnect.

4.6 The Studio voice

Creator-to-creator language: encouraging, structurally intelligent, and comfortable using ordinary design terms.

Where it appears: Authoring tools, Validation, Publishing, Versioning, Asset management, Preview.

- Create Chronicle
- Add chapter
- Add passage
- Preview from here
- Chapter IV cannot be published because it has no completion path.
- Publishing creates a permanent version. Existing voyages will continue using their current version.

Boundary rule

The UI must always know who owns the words. System copy, Captain instructions, Chronicle narration, character dialogue, and private creator notes are different content classes and must not leak into one another.

5. Error and Recovery Language

Errors should be calm, specific, honest, and actionable.

Every recovery message should answer four questions:

1. What happened?
2. Was anything lost?
3. What is the system doing now?
4. What can the user do next?

Situation	Heading	Supporting copy
Connection loss	Connection lost	Your progress is safe. Voyagewright is trying to reconnect.
Failed reconnect	Unable to reconnect	Your progress is saved through Chapter II. Check your connection, then try again.
Expired invitation	This invitation has expired	Ask the Captain to create a new invitation.
Publishing problem	The Chronicle was not published	Chapter III contains a passage with no valid destination. Your

Situation	Heading	Supporting copy
		draft has been preserved.
Unsupported content	This Chronicle requires a newer version of Voyagewright	Update the application before continuing. Your voyage has not advanced.
Verification failure	The object could not be confirmed	Adjust the view so the full marker is visible, then try again.

GOOD	The Chronicle could not be opened. Your progress has not changed. Try again, or return to the Library.
AVOID	Something went wrong.

6. Canonical Vocabulary

A shared vocabulary makes the product feel coherent and keeps implementation terminology from leaking into the interface.

Concept	Canonical term	Usage note
Authored playable experience	Chronicle	The central content object created in Studio.
Active playthrough	Voyage	A live or resumable instance of a Chronicle.
Person running the experience	Captain	The operator guiding a voyage.
Participating players	Crew	The people taking part in the voyage.
Major story division	Chapter	A large authored section of a Chronicle.
Individual authored unit	Passage	A narration, objective, riddle, choice, reveal, checkpoint, or transition.
Location or progression point	Waypoint	A destination, checkpoint, or meaningful position.
Optional discovered memory	Echo	A side discovery that deepens context without blocking progress.

Concept	Canonical term	Usage note
Significant collected object	Artifact	A discovered object with narrative meaning.
Completed-session record	Voyage Record	The durable history of a completed or ended voyage.
Creator application	Voyagewright Studio	The authoring and publishing interface.
Player application	Voyagewright Player	The player-facing experience.
Session-control application	Captain's Console	The live operating interface.
Test playthrough	Preview Voyage	A controlled test run of a draft or published version.
Completed or retired content storage	Archive	A clear ordinary term that requires no decorative synonym.

Why Passage works

Internally, the system may use a type such as StoryBlock. Creators should see Passage. A Passage can contain narration, a riddle, an objective, a confirmation, an artifact reveal, an image transformation, a choice, a Captain checkpoint, or a chapter ending. It feels authored and narrative without pretending every unit is a full scene.

Do not theme words that are already clear

Save, Cancel, Delete, Email, Password, Privacy, Version history, and Validation errors are already competent words. Renaming a password a 'secret Captain's cipher' would create charm for seven seconds and accessibility debt for years.

7. Microcopy Transformations

Replace generic or inherited language with copy that is clear, consistent, and distinctly Voyagewright.

Generic or inherited	Voyagewright
Start Tall Tale	Begin Chronicle
Active game session	Active Voyage
Create new story	Create Chronicle
Game master dashboard	Captain's Console
Continue	Continue Voyage

Generic or inherited	Voyagewright
Submit	Confirm Answer
You unlocked an item!	Artifact recovered
Waiting for admin	Awaiting the Captain
No data	Nothing has been recorded yet
Replay animation	Replay Presentation
Go back	Return to Library
End session	End Voyage
Duplicate campaign	Create a new voyage from this Chronicle
Error loading story	This Chronicle could not be opened
Testing mode	Preview Voyage
Draft game	Draft Chronicle

Microcopy pattern

For important Player events, use functional truth first and atmospheric meaning second.

Example: 'Chapter III released' followed by 'A new entry has opened in the journal.'

8. Sentence-Level Standards

Small language choices determine whether the product feels fluent or assembled.

Use sentence case

GOOD	Create Chronicle
AVOID	CREATE CHRONICLE NOW

Prefer active voice

GOOD	The Captain released Chapter II.
------	----------------------------------

AVOID

Chapter II has been released by the Captain.

Keep button labels short**GOOD**

Invite Crew

AVOID

Send an Invitation to Members of Your Crew

Use contractions naturally**GOOD**

We couldn't reconnect.

AVOID

We could not reconnect.

Use exclamation marks rarely**GOOD**

Settings saved.

AVOID

Settings saved!!!

Use ellipses only for ongoing actions**GOOD**

Reconnecting...

AVOID

A secret has been revealed...

Address the user directly when useful**GOOD**

Your progress is safe.

AVOID

The user's progress has been persisted.

Do not narrate internal emotion**GOOD**

The ribbon is faded. The knot is still holding.

AVOID

You feel a wave of sorrow.

Use concrete verbs**GOOD**

Release Chapter III

AVOID	Proceed with chapter-related action
--------------	-------------------------------------

Name the object

GOOD	This invitation has expired.
AVOID	It is no longer valid.

Punctuation and capitalization

- Use sentence case for buttons, labels, dialogs, and settings.
- Use title case only for proper product names, Chronicle titles, chapter titles, and named interfaces.
- Avoid decorative punctuation that competes with the content.
- Use an ellipsis only when the operation is genuinely continuing.
- Use exclamation marks for rare moments of real delight, not routine writes to a database.

9. Language Across the Emotional Arc

Language should change with the Chronicle's pacing without changing Voyagewright's underlying integrity.

Stage	Tone	Language behavior	Example
Early Chronicle	Energetic, curious, lightly playful	Shorter sentences, clearer direction, more room for restrained humor.	<i>The journal opens reluctantly. Its clasp seems to have opinions.</i>
Middle movement	Observant and widening	More space, fewer jokes, increasing attention to earlier details and altered meaning.	<i>This route was never abandoned. It was left unfinished for someone else.</i>
Reflection chapters	Quiet and concrete	Less interface chatter, simpler language, attention to ordinary objects and physical evidence.	<i>The ribbon is faded. The knot is still holding.</i>
Finale	Minimal and spacious	No marketing language, no emotional instructions, no unnecessary explanation, and clear moral agency.	<i>The Compass has chosen its bearing. What remains is yours to decide.</i>

Narrative rule

Reveal the thing. Do not explain the correct emotional response to the thing.

10. Speaker Ownership

Every meaningful line should have a known speaker and delivery context.

Speaker ownership prevents system errors from sounding like Chronicle narration, private Captain notes from appearing in Player content, and one Chronicle's voice from leaking into another.

Recommended content ownership fields

- speakerType
- speakerId
- voiceProfile
- deliveryContext
- audience
- tone
- visibility
- localizationKey
- contentVersion

Recommended speaker types

Speaker type	Purpose
SYSTEM	Neutral platform information, status, errors, and recovery.
NARRATOR	Chronicle-authored narrative voice.
CHARACTER	Named or implied character dialogue.
CAPTAIN_OPERATOR	Instructions or messages sent by the live Captain.
CREATOR	Creator-authored notes and guidance.
PLAYER	Player-generated responses or submissions.
UNATTRIBUTED_DOCUMENT	Letters, journals, plaques, signs, or found text without a speaking character.
System behavior The interface should always be able to answer: Who is speaking? To whom? In what context? Is this line platform-owned, Chronicle-owned, or user-generated?	

11. Nautical Intensity

The nautical metaphor should create identity without limiting the platform's future.

Surface	Approximate nautical intensity	Guidance
Brand and marketing	40%	Voyage, chart, course, crew, lantern, Chronicle.
Navigation and product terminology	25%	Library, Voyage, Captain, Studio, Archive.
Ordinary app controls	10%	Prefer Save, Cancel, Delete, Password, Privacy.
Captain's Console	15%	Operational language with light nautical framing.
Voyagewright Studio	5-10%	Use ordinary creator and publishing terminology.
Errors, security, privacy, billing	0%	Direct, literal, and unthemed.
Chronicle content	Author-defined	The Chronicle's genre and narrator control the voice.

The metaphor of a voyage can support a pirate mystery, science-fiction expedition, fantasy pilgrimage, detective investigation, romantic scavenger hunt, historical walking tour, horror experience, or cooperative puzzle campaign. Fake pirate speech cannot.

12. Accessibility and Localization

Fluent language must remain understandable, translatable, and usable by assistive technology.

Accessibility language requirements

- Do not use atmosphere as the only carrier of status or instruction.
- Pair poetic supporting copy with a literal heading when the action matters.
- Do not encode success, warning, or error only through color or decorative iconography.
- Use button labels that remain meaningful outside visual context.
- Avoid idioms in security, privacy, verification, and recovery messages.
- Preserve the same semantic order in full, gentle, and reduced-motion modes.
- Do not shame the user for requesting hints, using accessibility settings, or failing verification.
- Keep status announcements concise enough for screen readers.

Localization requirements

- Store platform strings separately from Chronicle-authored prose.
- Use stable localization keys rather than using English copy as identifiers.

- Avoid string concatenation that produces broken grammar in other languages.
- Allow button widths and dialog layouts to expand for longer translations.
- Preserve speaker identity and tone metadata through translation workflows.
- Do not translate Chronicle names, character names, or invented terms without creator intent.
- Provide translators with context, audience, and speaker information.

Plain-language override

When safety, privacy, data loss, payment, or account access is involved, literal language overrides atmosphere.

13. Copy Governance

Voice quality survives only when it becomes part of the workflow.

Required governance artifacts

- A canonical terminology registry shared by product, design, engineering, documentation, and marketing.
- A screen-by-screen copy inventory with ownership and status.
- Reusable patterns for errors, confirmations, loading states, empty states, hints, and invitations.
- A Chronicle voice profile schema for narrator and character guidance.
- A content review checklist included in pull requests and release reviews.
- Automated detection for banned inherited terms such as Tall Tale in platform-owned copy.
- Versioned migration notes when canonical terminology changes.

Recommended review sequence

5. Confirm the speaker and audience.
6. Write the functional truth in plain language.
7. Add only the atmosphere that improves the moment.
8. Check the canonical glossary.
9. Check the action label independently from surrounding visual context.
10. Verify error and recovery copy explains impact and next action.
11. Test reduced-motion, mobile, and screen-reader presentation.
12. Review the line inside the complete user flow, not in isolation.

Implementation rule

Do not polish language piecemeal while terminology remains unsettled. Establish the glossary and voice layers first, then audit the product systematically.

14. Definitive Voice Statement

The governing statement for all future copy decisions.

Voyagewright speaks with measured wonder. It is warm, observant, precise, and quietly imaginative. It uses nautical language as texture rather than

costume. It gives clear direction, trusts the player's intelligence, protects their dignity, and never explains an emotion that the experience can earn. The platform speaks as a guide; the Chronicle speaks through its own author and characters.

The three-line test

Clear first.
Human always.
Wonder earned.

Decision rule

When two versions are equally clear, choose the more human one. When one version is clearer, choose clarity. When neither is clear, stop decorating the sentence and fix the sentence.

Appendix A. Sample Copy Library

Onboarding

Heading or action	Supporting copy
Welcome to Voyagewright	Create a Chronicle, gather your crew, and turn a familiar world into a story made for them.
Choose your role	Join as a Player, guide the voyage as Captain, or create in Studio.
No account yet?	Create one to save your Chronicles, voyages, and invitations.

Invitations

Heading or action	Supporting copy
You've been invited	A Captain has invited you to join a voyage.
Invitation accepted	Your place in the crew is confirmed.
Invitation expired	Ask the Captain to create a new invitation.
Crew member joined	Kato has joined the voyage.

Player progression

Heading or action	Supporting copy
Chapter released	A new entry has opened in the journal.
Waypoint revealed	A new bearing has been marked on the chart.
Artifact recovered	The object has been added to your collection.
Echo discovered	This memory is optional, but it may change what the journey means.
Awaiting the Captain	Your progress is saved. The voyage will continue when the next passage is released.

Captain controls

Heading or action	Supporting copy
Release chapter	Make the next chapter available to the crew.
Approve discovery	Confirm the player's submission and advance the voyage.
Send hint	Reveal the selected hint to the player.
Pause voyage	Players can keep reading, but progression controls will be suspended.
End voyage	The current voyage will close. Its record and progress will be preserved.

Studio

Heading or action	Supporting copy
Create Chronicle	Start with a title, premise, and first chapter.
Add passage	Choose narration, objective, riddle, choice, reveal, or Captain checkpoint.
Preview from here	Run the Chronicle from this passage without changing the draft.
Draft saved	Your latest changes are preserved.
Ready to publish	Publishing creates a permanent version for new voyages.
Cannot publish yet	Two passages have no valid destination.

Empty states

Heading or action	Supporting copy
No Chronicles yet	Every voyage starts with a first page.
No active voyages	Join an invitation or begin one from your Chronicle Library.
No artifacts recovered	Recovered artifacts will appear here.
No crew invited	Invite players when the Chronicle is ready.

Recovery

Heading or action	Supporting copy
Connection lost	Your progress is safe. Voyagewright is trying to reconnect.
Unable to reconnect	Your progress is preserved. Check your connection, then try again.
Upload incomplete	The file was not saved. Choose it again after checking your connection.
Voyage paused	The Captain has paused progression. Your current chapter remains available.

Appendix B. Copy Review Checklist

Speaker

- ☐ Is the speaker known?
- ☐ Is the audience known?
- ☐ Is this platform copy, Chronicle content, Captain communication, creator guidance, or user-generated text?
- ☐ Could this line leak private or unpublished information?

Clarity

- ☐ Does the user know what happened?
- ☐ Does the user know what to do next?
- ☐ Does the heading make sense without decorative supporting copy?
- ☐ Would the label remain clear outside its current visual layout?

Voice

- ☐ Does the line feel warm, precise, and restrained?
- ☐ Is nautical language serving comprehension or merely decorating it?
- ☐ Does the line trust the user's intelligence?
- ☐ Does it avoid prescribing emotion?

Tone

- ☐ Is the tone appropriate for the seriousness of the moment?
- ☐ Has humor been removed from security, privacy, billing, or data-loss states?
- ☐ Is a live Captain action direct enough to use under pressure?
- ☐ Is the finale quieter rather than louder?

Terminology

- ☐ Does the line use the canonical glossary?
- ☐ Has inherited Tall Tale language been removed from platform-owned copy?
- ☐ Are Save, Cancel, Delete, Password, Privacy, and Version history left literal where appropriate?
- ☐ Are Chronicle, Voyage, Chapter, Passage, Waypoint, Echo, and Artifact used consistently?

Accessibility and localization

- ☐ Can a screen reader understand the action and state?
- ☐ Is meaning conveyed without relying only on color, animation, or iconography?
- ☐ Will the string survive translation without concatenation problems?
- ☐ Does the translation context include speaker, audience, and delivery context?

Recovery

- ☐ Does the message explain whether progress or data was lost?
- ☐ Does it state what the system is doing now?
- ☐ Does it give a concrete next step?
- ☐ Does it preserve the user's dignity?

Final approval

A line is ready when it is clear without context, fluent within context, owned by the correct speaker, consistent with the glossary, and appropriate for accessibility, localization, and the emotional moment.

VOYAGEWRIGHT

Stories made to be played.